regional security cooperation they seek with India. Regarding connectivity with Southeast Asia, accelerating projects in India's North-East and improving the country's port and air infrastructure and connectivity still need to be higher priorities. However, all of these are subject to politics, sustainability and, most importantly, commercial viability. In Southeast Asia—a diverse and dynamic region abutting India—New Delhi is already doing a lot more than just looking east. But much work must still be done before India can play a sufficient balancing role.

Priority 7. Partner with the Quad and Others

India's challenges and obligations in the Indo–Pacific are already daunting, but particularly so given the power disparity between China and India. For this reason, partnerships with other balancing powers in the Indo–Pacific will be necessary. Because this will have to be limited to states that share similar concerns and worldviews as India and have sufficient military and economic capabilities, particularly in the maritime domain, the candidates are few. The most important and obvious is the United States. Another is Japan, which remains economically potent and, despite its traditionally pacifist orientation, has embarked upon significant defence reforms to enable it to play the role of a military balancer as well. Australia is also playing a more active role, and there is scope for India to partner with South Korea, Taiwan, France, the United Kingdom and others with a presence and influence in the Indo–Pacific. Equally, India will have to carefully manage its longstanding defence relationship with Russia in the light of closer China–Russia relations.

India does not seek a military alliance in the region. For some countries, notably the United States, an alliance is a specific agreement, normally ratified, which often commits the countries to mutual defence, joint command structures, and basing arrangements (or at least 'status of forces agreements' that give a legal structure to foreign military forces). Such agreements require a high level of interdependence, commitment, and seamlessness of operations. The US has five such treaty allies in the Indo–